

Branding Guide: Baseline

Brand Foundation

Mission: Help mid-scale commodity farmers validate profitability decisions with independent data, enabling confident negotiations with lenders and agronomists.

Vision: A future where farmers have peer-benchmarked financial clarity before committing to input costs, shifting from anxiety to agency.

Core Values: - Honesty: Radical transparency about capabilities, limits, and what the data actually shows - Partnership: Enable advisors and lenders; never position as replacement - Respect: Honor farmer expertise; teach new concepts, not their business - Clarity: Specific data and concrete outcomes over vague claims

Brand Promise: Baseline gives you the independent financial data you need to understand your margin impact before March—so you know where you stand.

Brand Personality

Personality Traits: - Pragmatic: Focused on real problems and concrete solutions - Direct: Plainspoken Midwest language; no jargon or hype - Trustworthy: Honest about limits; backs claims with data - Mentor-like: Guides without directing; invites reflection

Brand Archetype: The Mentor

If Baseline were a person: - They would be: An experienced agronomist or ag finance advisor who respects your expertise, shows you data you don't have, and helps you make decisions with confidence - They would never: Hype features, oversimplify your business, patronize you, or claim to replace your trusted advisors

Target Audience

Primary Audience: - Mid-scale commodity farmers (500–5,000 acres, corn/soybean) - Midwest (Missouri, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana primary) - Age 40–60, digitally-forward relative to peers - Currently spending \$200–300/month on fragmented tools

What They Value: - Independent data to push back on advisors - Peer benchmarking to validate decisions - Honest assessment of downside scenarios - Clear visibility into margin impact before commitment

How They Want to Feel: - When discovering Baseline: Relief (someone understands my March anxiety) - When using the product: Confident (I know where I stand with real data)

Voice & Tone Guidelines

Voice (Consistent Across All Channels): - Problem-first: Lead with farmer anxiety, then show solution - Data-specific: Use concrete numbers, not vague claims - Plainspoken: Direct Midwest language; no startup jargon - Partnership-oriented: Position as tool/enabler, not advisor replacement

Tone (Varies by Context): - Homepage: Solution-focused, specific to March crisis moment - Social: Educational (LinkedIn formal, Facebook peer-to-peer) - Email: Warm, clear, action-oriented - In-product: Matter-of-fact, invitational, grounded in farmer expertise

Vocabulary: - Use: Know, margin, scenario, peer, spend, decision, validate - Avoid: Empower, transform, revolutionary, innovative, disrupt, leverage

Visual Direction

Color Palette: - Primary: Teal (#0D8B8B or similar) – Trust + clarity + data confidence, not generic agtech green - Secondary: Warm Charcoal (#4A4A4A) + Cream (#F5F3F0) – Midwest practicality, grounded, approachable - Accent: Warm Gold/Ochre (#D4A574) – Agricultural roots without cliché; use for CTAs, data highlights - Supporting: Clean Whites – Data visualization, UI readability

Typography: - Headlines: Montserrat (medium weight) – Confident, clear, not aggressive - Body: Lato – Clean, readable on mobile, friendly without casual

Imagery Style: - Photography: Documentary-professional (real farmers in real moments, good lighting, authentic action, not posed) - Subject matter: Real farmers making decisions, screens/data visualizations, farmer-advisor collaboration, Midwest geography - What to avoid: Stock photos, pastoral/scenic imagery, generic happy farmers, equipment as hero, clichés, nonprofit feeling

Messaging Framework

Tagline: "See what they see" (4 words; mystery of "they" intriguing; positions information asymmetry as core problem)

Value Proposition: For mid-scale commodity farmers uncertain about input timing and cash flow, Baseline is a scenario planning tool that models margin impact and shows how you compare to regional peers. Unlike spreadsheets and advisor-dependent planning, we give you independent data to validate profitability and negotiate with lenders and agronomists from a position of confidence.

Elevator Pitch (30 sec): Here's the problem: farmers commit to input costs in March but don't know if their margins will work until November—too late to change course. Baseline fixes that. We model scenarios anchored in what farms like yours are actually spending—so you actually know where you stand before March.

Key Messages by Channel

Website Homepage: - Headline: "Know your margins before March" - Subheadline: "Model scenarios grounded in what farms like yours are spending. See the impact before you commit to input costs."

Social Media: - LinkedIn Bio: "Financial scenario planning for mid-scale farmers. Model margins. See your peers. Own your decisions." - Facebook Bio: "Know your margins before March. Scenario planning for farmers who own their finances." - Post Style: Data insights + educational content + problem/solution framings + peer benchmarking angles + success stories - LinkedIn Tone: Professional, thought leadership, agronomist/co-op focused - Facebook Tone: Conversational, farmer-to-farmer, Midwest-authentic, stories over data

Email: - Onboarding Subject Lines: "Your first scenario is ready" / "Ready to see your margin impact?" - Nurture Subject Lines: "Your peers are managing input timing differently" / "Why March matters for your margins" - Sign-off: [Founder Name], Founder, Baseline; "Looking forward to helping you own your margins."

In-Product Moments: - Empty State: "Ready to see your margin impact? You'll need three things: seed cost, fertilizer cost, expected yield. We'll handle the math. (Takes ~15 minutes with agronomist support if you want it.)" - Success Moment: "Here's your scenario: If seed costs rise 15%, your margin drops to \$X/acre. How does that compare to farms like yours? [View peer comparison.] What does this tell you about your decision?" - Negative Insight: "Your seed cost is higher than 70% of similar farms in your region. Worth exploring. [See regional breakdown.] What's driving the difference in your operation?" - Positive Insight: "Your fertilizer cost is lower than 85% of similar farms in your region. That's a strength. [See regional breakdown.] How are you maintaining that advantage?"

Brand Do's and Don'ts

DO: - Lead with the farmer's problem (cash flow gap, March pressure, information asymmetry), then solution. Never open with "Baseline is a scenario tool." - Use specific data and concrete outcomes ("Your margin improves \$2,400", not "significant improvements"). Numbers build credibility. - Acknowledge limits and be radically honest ("Week 1 entry can be manual or agronomist-assisted"; "We're testing this approach"). Honesty builds trust. - Position Baseline as tool/partner, not advisor. Enable farmer decision-making; don't direct it. Ask "What does this mean for your operation?" - Validate farmer expertise and intuition. Confirm their concerns with data; show they've been thinking about the right things. - Use Midwest plainspoken language ("Know your margins", not "gain margin visibility"). Direct, economical, no jargon.

DON'T: - Use hype language (revolutionary, game-changing, disruptive, innovative, transform, empower). Farmers know BS. Baseline is a tool that works. That's enough. - Oversell AI/technology ("AI-powered scenario modeling"). Lead with outcome (peer benchmarking), not tech stack. - Patronize farmers or assume ignorance. Never explain commodity pricing, margins, basic ag economics. Teach new concepts only (benchmarking, scenario modeling). - Use agricultural clichés or pastoral imagery (sunset cornfields, farmers smiling in fields, "harvest success"). We solve business problems, not sell romance. - Make promises you can't keep ("100% accurate forecasting", "Guarantee X% improvement", "Know exactly what will happen in March"). Honest limits are more credible. - Compete with or undermine advisors. Never position as "better than your agronomist" or frame as "replace your advisor". We enable advisors. - Oversimplify or dumb down. Simplify the UX, not the economics. Farmers respect tools that honor actual complexity.

When in Doubt: "Would a farmer trust this? Does this sound like a Mentor talking to a peer, or like marketing talking at them?" Follow-up questions: Am I respecting their expertise or explaining their business? Am I showing something true or selling something? Am I honest about limits? Does this sound like a Midwest farmer or a Silicon Valley startup? If the answer is "marketing talking at them" or "startup BS," rewrite it.